New protests further strain Modi's electoral coalition

送信者: EG South Asia 受信日時: 2026-10-16 03:28

【メール原文】

The protests pose little threat to Modi’s government. Unlike the student unrest of June and July, led by the Cockroach Janata Party youth movement, th

India
Customize Email Preferences

Electoral roll protests further strain Modi’s electoral coalition

15 Oct 2026 14:27 EDT Discover more on the Portal
Short-term trajectory:
Long-term trajectory:

*
The government’s zero-casualty crowd control and rollback of controversial electoral roll rules have confined the protests to a few cities.
*
The protests have failed to create a united opposition, which could have been a genuine electoral threat to Prime Minister Narendra Modi.
*
However, the protests have aggravated caste divisions within the core electoral coalition of Modi’s ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

The protests pose little threat to Modi’s government. Unlike the student unrest of June and July, led by the Cockroach Janata Party youth movement, the protests in New Delhi over the past week were led by opposition parties. The result was a much larger protest, one that led to the shutdown of the city center. The government’s primary goal was to prevent casualties for fear they would encourage sympathetic protests nationwide and broader civil society involvement. Crowd control depended on preventive detentions and the deployment of masses of unarmed police to disperse crowds. This approach proved successful. While some demonstrations continue in New Delhi and other cities, they have been limited in size.

The trigger for the latest protests was evidence that the deletion of millions of voters from the electoral rolls violated established procedures. The issue has so far garnered limited public support. The government further defused the controversy by leaving the future of the election commissioner (who clearly did not follow expected procedures) to the Supreme Court, rolling back some of the more controversial electoral roll rules, and fast-tracking a review process to restore many of the deleted names.

The opposition parties and the youth protesters will remain divided. Although youth leaders took part in the opposition-led march to the Supreme Court on 12 October, the creation of a larger anti-BJP front remains elusive. The BJP and its allies command about a 40% vote share and would be vulnerable to a unified opposition. Large-scale social protests that lead to a united front toppling an overreaching prime

minister is a recurring pattern in Indian politics, but the latest actions have so far failed to reach a tipping point against Modi.

Instead, the protests have been marked by divisions within the opposition alliance led by the Congress Party. Many regional parties that joined the New Delhi protests declined to organize protests in the states or cities they controlled. The most powerful opposition leader in southern India, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay, who is allied with the Congress Party, declined to participate or even comment on the protests. Youth leaders and opposition parties also did not unite—many opposition leaders continue to see the youth movement as too fragmented and too narrow-based to be politically consequential.

However, the protests are helping weaken Modi's electoral coalition. The demonstrations in both June-July and October have fed into Hindu upper caste discontent, a pre-existing political challenge for the BJP. Modi's electoral strength has arisen from the successful union of Hindu upper castes and lower-middle castes (known as other backward castes, or OBCs). This core has been augmented with chunks of low-caste and tribal voters. The upper-caste and OBC core, however, has begun to fray. Upper-caste Hindus have increasingly come to see the Modi government as favoring OBCs in terms of job and educational quotas, cabinet berths, and overall messaging. Economic concerns about jobs and inflation are the main drivers of this discontent, not worries about constitutional norms.

The shift has manifested itself in recent by-elections and municipal polls in northern and western India, where upper castes registered their dissent by switching their vote to independent candidates. The initial student protestors in June-July were disproportionately upper caste. Opposition parties have already begun wooing disaffected BJP supporters, though so far with limited success.

The BJP remains divided on how to respond to the fraying of its base. With three major state elections in northern India scheduled for February next year, including the most populous state, Uttar Pradesh, the BJP is divided on how to respond. It can do little about youth unemployment in the near term, given the scale of the problem—about one-third of college graduates are out of work. While Modi remains popular, his approval rating has fallen 21 percentage points over the past three years—more so among young northern Indians. Approval for Modi used to be nearly twice the BJP's vote share; today the figures are almost the same. That shift has raised doubts about the strength of his coattail effect on the campaign trail.

One segment of the BJP argues the party should double down on the more populous OBCs. Members of this group note that in five by-elections in the month leading up to the October protests, the BJP won three in eastern India. The BJP's rising support in the east, as well as increased OBC support, would, over time, compensate for upper-caste defections. However, most of the BJP leadership opposes what would amount to abandoning the party's original base. Instead, the party will likely pursue a series of incremental steps, including health care-focused welfare programs, education reforms, efforts to attract women voters in northern India, and the appointment of more upper-caste leaders to the cabinet, to strengthen its position before the February elections.

Pramit Chaudhuri
Practice Head, South Asia
chaudhuri.ne@eurasiagroup.net

Rahul Bhatia
Analyst, South Asia
bhatia.ne@eurasiagroup.net
EG South Asia
southasia@eurasiagroup.net

© 2026 Eurasia Group. All rights reserved. This material was produced by Eurasia Group for use by the recipient. This is intended as general background research and is not intended to constitute advice on any particular commercial investment or trade matter or issue and should not be relied upon for such purposes. It is not to be made available to any person other than the recipient. No part of this publication may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic or otherwise, without the prior consent of Eurasia Group.
X-HG-DocID cmv9u15p602m707mvfnggt7wd

Opt Out | Customize Email Preferences